

Compaq Presario S5030iL

Built to last

The Compaq S5030iL has a distinctive silver-black look, and an impeccable build quality that was not matched by other PCs. Its JBL platinum speakers yield great output when placed on the desktop.

It comes with 128 MB DDR RAM, a 40 GB 5400 rpm drive and a Pentium 4 2.4 GHz on a SiS 650 chipset-based motherboard that has an AGP slot, three PCI slots and offers onboard LAN, video and six-channel sound. The multimedia keyboard and optical mouse were the best we saw in the comparison. Also bundled along, is a 56K PCI modem. No additional software such as anti-virus suites and office applications have been provide; nor are Windows drivers. The S5030iL's performance was mediocre, since its components could not keep up with the processor. It finished third in the Audio encoding test.

Similarly, the gaming tests proved it to be no head turner. The onboard graphics could hardly match the latest gaming requirements; the 3Dmark2001 SE test simply failed to run due the lack of enough RAM. This was also the cause for poor scores in the ZDbench test. An extra 128 MB RAM will help boost its performance. Also, since it comes bundled with Turbo Linux, you will need to shell out some extra cash for Windows.

At Rs 36,150, it's slightly expensive but expect solid build quality and good reliability in return.

Price: Rs 36,150
+ Decent performance
- Just 128 MB RAM

Compaq Presario S5030iL		B
Performance	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	
Features	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	
Build quality	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	
Value for money	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	

Compaq Presario S5010iL

No beauty in this beast

The S5010iL is similar in design, build and aesthetics to its Pentium sibling. It has an AMD Athlon XP 2400+ mounted on an MSI motherboard, based on VIA KM266 chipset with a mere 128 MB DDR RAM. The onboard video controller displays lacklustre performance. The motherboard has one AGP slot, three PCI slots, two memory slots, onboard LAN and six USB ports. The multimedia keyboard and the optical mouse are a delight to use. A 56K PCI modem is also provided.

Turbo Linux is pre-installed and a Linux recovery CD is provided; no additional software is given.

The S5010iL failed miserably in certain tests. Though on par with most of the PCs in the pure processor test, it nose-dived in the video encoding

and audio encoding tests despite its DDR RAM. The graphic sub-system yielded very poor results while running *Quake III* at 640 x 480; changing the resolution caused the system to reset. *UT2003* ran at the normal and high settings, but failed when we set it to the maximum. The same was true for the hard disk tests where the results were below par.

However, it displayed decent scores in the ZDbench test and handled the load with aplomb in the multi-tasking test.

Though it's relatively cheap at Rs 27,500, it has many chinks in its armour, namely the scanty software bundle and its below par performance.

Price: Rs 27,500
+ Good build quality
- Dismal performance

Compaq Presario S5010iL		B+
Performance	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	
Features	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	
Build quality	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	
Value for money	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	

Dart Emerald Value PC

Low on features, decent performance

The Value PC came in a metallic black tower complimented well by a black monitor. The roomy cabinet looked quite nice with metal studs on the plastic dummies in the front.

A good configuration comprising a 2.4 GHz Pentium 4 and a 40 GB Seagate Barracuda hard drive was marred by the presence of just 128 MB RAM. Three PCI slots have been provided—there is no AGP slot. The absence of an optical drive surprised us, as they are very cheap. The mundane multimedia keyboard and the optical mouse sported enhanced ergonomics. The absence of a LAN card, a PCI modem and speakers also marked it negatively. Accompanied by Windows XP Home Edition, it had no other additional software.

Performance-wise, the P4 2.4 GHz was mainly responsible for the decent scores in the processor sub-system tests, while the 128 MB RAM marred the results in the memory-intensive tests. It gave a commendable 132 frames at lower resolutions for *Quake III*. However, *UT2003* saw the frame-rate drop below playable rates, indicating that the onboard graphics barely meet the latest gaming requirements. Similarly, the ZDbench test saw it pitching in an average performance.

The expensive price tag seems fine when you consider the bundled Windows operating system and the 3-years warranty. Had it not been for the missing optical drive and speakers, this otherwise balanced offering from Dart would have been complete.

Price: Rs 35,000
+ Bundled Windows OS
- No CD-ROM drive

Dart Emerald PC		B-
Performance	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	
Features	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	
Build quality	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	
Value for money	▬ ▬ ▬ ▬ ▬	